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Amazon 2018

Business Strategy and Financial Strategy

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Introduction

With sales of $178 billion, Amazon.com, Inc. was the biggest internet retailer in the world in 2017, and with around 250 million items in its catalogue it was considered to be the biggest general store worldwide.

Amazon's annual growth (average 36% in the last decade), in spite of its big size, was striking. In comparison, the average annual growth rate of the retail business in the U.S. was only 2% in the last decade. Amazon was expected to reach $250 billion in sales by the end of 2018, driven by low prices, its wide range of products, and its positive customer experience.

As a result of Amazon's strong growth, the market capitalization of Amazon had tripled in the last 4 years (2013-17) reaching $566 billion. All these factors attracted the interest of investors, analysts, regulators, and the public.

In February 2018, John Allen, a fund manager, was considering the possibility of buying shares of Amazon. John collected the financial statements of Amazon from 1995 to 2017. The first step was to simplify the financial statements so that he could get clear conclusions out of the numbers (see Exhibits 1 and 2).

John also gathered plenty of information available on the web but relied mainly on the Annual Report Form 10-K,[1] submitted to the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) for the fiscal year of 2017.

[1] A 10-K form gives a comprehensive summary of a company's financial performance: audited financial statements, company history, organizational structure, executive compensation, equity, subsidiaries, among other information. Form 10-K, as well as other SEC filings, can be searched using the EDGAR database on the SEC's website. Although similarly named, the annual report on Form 10-K is distinct from the "annual report to shareholders".

This case was prepared by Professors Eduardo Martínez Abascal and Christian Eufinger, with the collaboration of Professor Oscar Simões for the Portuguese version. October 2019.
IESE cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.

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Remembering his time as an MBA student, John summarized the main facts in a case study that could be discussed afterwards. In fact, the case would be a summary of the 10-K Form in a more palatable format.

Prior to the valuation process, John wanted to understand the business, its past, present, perspectives, and risks. He wanted solid opinions based on data. Afterwards, he would do the valuation to decide whether to buy Amazon's shares or not.

Now, take the role of John and do your own analysis of Amazon.

Amazon's Mission and Principles

Amazon is guided by four principles: *"customer obsession rather than competitor focus, passion for invention, commitment to operational excellence, and long-term thinking."*[2]

Amazon's Main Businesses (Products and Customers)

Amazon's customers consist of retail consumers, sellers, developers, enterprises, and content creators. Amazon operates in many businesses, which can be summarized in the following five categories.

Online retailer. Amazon sells virtually everything (250 million references in its catalogue) to hundreds of millions of customers in the entire world. Sales of products reached $108 billion, or 61% of Amazon's total sales. Accumulated growth in the last three years (2014-17) was 58% (see Exhibit 3, Table 1). Cost of goods sold were reported in the P&L as 94% of sales. Many analysts attributed the growth to the success of the Amazon Prime program.[3] The investments (and expenses) in logistics and web development, required for this business, were huge.

Amazon also manufactures and sells electronic devices, including Kindle e-readers, Fire tablets, Fire TVs, and Echo, and develops and produces media content. Their retail strategy focuses on selection, low prices, and convenience.

Marketplace or Third party seller services. Around 2 million sellers from 100 countries sell their products through Amazon Marketplace. These sales represent around half of the 4 billion items sold by Amazon. For this service Amazon charges a fixed fee and/or a percentage of sales that are accounted in the P&L as services. Amazon offers all type of services to third party sellers, like web, marketing, fulfillment (logistics, transportation, customer services, etc.).

Revenue from third party seller services reached $32 billion or 18% of Amazon's total sales and this business was growing very fast. Accumulated growth in the last three years (2014-17) was 171% (see Exhibit 3, Table 1). Estimates suggest that Amazon has a higher operating profit in its marketplace than with its own products sold.

Subscription services. Includes annual/monthly fees associated with the Amazon Prime membership, audiobooks, e-books, digital video, digital music, etc.

[2] Phrases in italic format are taken literally from Amazon's 10-K Form.

[3] Prime subscriptions are estimated to be at around 60 to 90 million in the U.S. alone. According to Amazon, these customers spend twice as much as other regular customers (around $1,200/year).

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Amazon web services (AWS). Amazon offers a broad set of global computing (cloud service), storage, database, and other services to companies and institutions. In 2017, AWS represented 10% of total revenue ($17 billion), with an operating profit (EBIT) of $4.3 billion, (105% of total EBIT of Amazon). It was also the segment with the highest growth, that is, 122% from 2015 to 2017 (see Exhibit 3, Table 3 and 4).

Content creators. Amazon offers programs that allow authors, musicians, filmmakers, app developers, and others to publish and sell content (Kindle Store, Amazon Publishing, etc.).

Physical stores. This segment was created in 2017 and it includes bookstores, pop-ups, and *amazon 4-stars,*[4] which together represent 3% of Amazon's sales mix and $6 billion (see Exhibit 3, Table 1). With the acquisition of Whole Foods, Amazon is also moving into grocery stores.

Other. Represents sales not otherwise included in the previous business categories, such as certain advertising services and the co-branded credit card agreements.

Sales of each business category are presented in Exhibit 3, Table 1; the geographical distribution of sales is shown in Table 2. Amazon does not provide information about profitability of its businesses; all the information is related to what Amazon calls "segments".

Market Segments

Amazon has organized its operations into three market segments: North America, International, and AWS.[5] See Exhibit 3, with the following information:

- Sales by market segment (Table 3).
- Operating income (EBIT) by market segment (Table 4).
- Total assets by market segment (Table 5).
- ROA (return on assets) by market segment (Table 6).
- Retail industry and competition (Table 7).

P&L Comments

Amazon's P&L and balance sheet for years 2013-2017 are presented in Exhibits 1 and 2.[6]

- Net sale of products refers to sales in the retail business; net sale of services refers to the revenue from all other business segments (third-party seller or Marketplace, AWS, etc.). The breakdown of revenue by business segments is shown in Exhibit 3, Table 1.
- Amazon reports that usually 33% of annual sales are generated in the fourth quarter.
- Cost of revenue refers to the purchasing price of products from suppliers plus shipping costs; it is mainly part of the retail business.

[4] Amazon 4-stars are physical supermarkets located in big cities. They sell the best-rated and the best-selling products from amazon.

[5] Annual report 2017, page 68, Note 11 Segment information.

[6] In the Excel doc (available on the web), you may see the P&L and balance sheet from 1995 to 2017.

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- Marketing costs consist primarily of targeted online advertising, television advertising, public relations expenditures, and payroll for personnel engaged in marketing and selling activities.
- General and administrative costs refer to costs related to corporate functions like accounting, finance, tax, legal, and human resources, etc., plus costs related to the use of facilities.
- Technology costs refer to costs related to the maintenance and operation of software, hardware, and technology necessary for the business. A major part of the costs related to AWS is included in this position.
- Fulfillment costs refer mainly to logistics and customer services.
- Amazon significantly increased fulfilment and technology expenses to ensure present and future growth.

Financial Strategy: P&L and Balance Sheet Policies

Amazon's financial strategy can be summarized as follows:[7]

- Focus on long-term, sustainable growth.
- Low COGS through direct sourcing and discounts from suppliers.
- Quickly turn inventory.
- Invest efficiently in technology and content.

Retail Industry and Competition

In 2017, total revenue of the retail industry in the U.S. was $3.14 trillion, with an accumulated growth of 11% from 2014 to 2017, which was similar to the growth of the economy in general (around 3.6% per year). Store-based retailing represented 82% of the total industry revenue, but it was growing less than the economy (6% from 2014 to 2017 or 2.1% annually). Internet retailing was 12% of the retail industry with an accumulated growth of 56% (16% annually). Others, like home shopping, vending, direct sell, etc., represented 6% of the industry with accumulated growth of 18% (6% annually). Amazon accounts for 28% of all online retail sales in the US and 3% of total retail sales (see Exhibit 3, Table 7).[8]

The revenue of the retail industry in the world in 2017 was estimated at $14.23 trillion, with an accumulated growth of just 1% from 2014 to 2017 (0.2% annually). Internet retailing reached $1.48 trillion in 2017 (10% of total retail) with an accumulated growth of 68% (19% annually).

While analysts usually compared Amazon with big retailers in the U.S. (Walmart, CVS, etc.), Amazon had a much higher growth rate but lower profits. Amazon was often seen as the retailer

[7] This section is a summary of pages 19-20 of Form 10-K. *Management's Discussion and Analysis of Financial Condition and Results of Operations*.

[8] Source: Retailing Market Sizes, Euromonitor International.

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of the future. However, traditional retailers were investing heavily in internet retailing and this posed a clear threat to Amazon (see Exhibit 4, Table 1).

The differences between Amazon and other pure online retailers (Alibaba, eBay, etc.) were not considerable. The only major concern was the much higher profitability of the Chinese Alibaba (Exhibit 4, Table 2).

Amazon was considered to be a member of the four technology giants: Google, Amazon, Facebook, and Apple (see data in Exhibit 4, Table 3).

According to Amazon: "*Our businesses encompass a large variety of products types, services and delivery channels. We face a broad array of competitors from many different sectors around the world."* These include:

- Retailers, publishers, vendors, distributors, manufacturers, and producers of the products Amazon sells;
- Web search engines, comparison shopping websites, social networks;
- E-commerce, fulfillment and logistics, and information technology service providers;
- Consumer electronics and telecommunication companies.

Moreover, each of Amazon's businesses is also subject to rapid change of new business models and the entry of new and well-funded competitors.[9]

The principal competitive factors in Amazon's retail businesses include selection, price, and convenience, which includes fast and reliable fulfillment (delivery). Competitive factors for their services include quality, speed, and reliability, as well as customers' ability and willingness to change business practices.

Management and People

All seven executive officers are between 48 and 54 years old, and all have been with the company for more than 10 years and were internally promoted. The board of directors consists of 11 people (ages 54 to 77) with different professional backgrounds.

As of December 31, 2017, Amazon employed approximately 566,000 employees (28% more than the previous year). However, employment levels fluctuate due to seasonal factors. Additionally, Amazon utilizes independent contractors and temporary personnel to supplement their workforce.

According to Amazon, *"competition for qualified personnel has historically been intense, particularly for software engineers, computer scientists, and other technical staff."* Amazon utilizes restricted stock units[10] as the primary vehicle for equity compensation.

[9] Amazon gives a long, detailed (often redundant) list of around 110 potential risks on pages 6-14 of its 10-K for the purpose of protecting itself against legal litigation.

[10] The stocks that can be sold by the employee only after a certain number of years (or upon reaching certain objectives).

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Strategy and Management Principles

Jeff Bezos stated Amazon's strategy in his 1997 letter to the shareholders, a copy of which is included in every annual report since then. A summary follows.

- Amazon's goal is to achieve long-term market leadership and an enduring franchise. These will bring higher revenue, profitability, and increased return on capital and shareholder value.
- Relentless focus on customers. True customer obsession.
- Aggressive investments to expand customer base, brand, and infrastructure, in spite of possible negative short-term reactions from Wall Street.
- Lean and cost-conscious culture.

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Exhibit 1
Amazon.com Inc. P&L Adjusted

P&L (Bill.$)	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	
Net product sales	61	70	79	95	119	
Net service sales	14	19	28	41	59	
Net Sales or Revenue	**74**	**89**	**107**	**136**	**178**	
Cost of Revenue (COGS)	54	63	72	88	112	
Gross Profit (Gross margin)	**20**	**26**	**35**	**48**	**66**	
Marketing	3	4	5	7	10	
General & Administrative	1	2	2	2	4	
Technology & Content. Research & Development	7	9	13	16	23	
Fulfillment & Other Operating Expense	9	11	14	18	25	
Operating Expenses (OPEX)	**20**	**26**	**33**	**44**	**62**	*Acc.*
Operating Income (EBIT)	**0.8**	**0.3**	**2.2**	**4.2**	**4.1**	*12*
Non-Operating (Income) Loss	0.2	0.3	0.7	0.3	0.3	
Abnormal Losses (Gains)	0.0	0.2	0.0	0.0	0.0	
Pretax Income (Loss), GAAP	**0.5**	**-0.1**	**1.6**	**3.9**	**3.8**	
Income Tax Expense (Benefit)	0.2	0.2	1.0	1.4	0.8	
Income (Loss) from Cont. Ops	**0.3**	**-0.2**	**0.6**	**2.4**	**3.0**	*6*
EBITDA	***4.0***	***5.1***	***8.5***	***12.3***	***15.6***	*46*

P&L Ratios	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	Averag
Product sales growth	*18%*	*15%*	*13%*	*19%*	*25%*	*18%*
Service sales growth	*45%*	*40%*	*47%*	*49%*	*43%*	*45%*
Sales growth	*22%*	*20%*	*20%*	*27%*	*31%*	***24%***
Opex growth	*36%*	*34%*	*27%*	*31%*	*42%*	***34%***
Product gross margin %	*11%*	*11%*	*10%*	*7%*	*6%*	
Gross Margin / Sales	*27%*	*30%*	*33%*	*35%*	*37%*	***+10pp***
Opex / Sales	*26%*	*29%*	*31%*	*32%*	*35%*	***+9pp***
EBIT / Sales	*1%*	*0%*	*2%*	*3%*	*2%*	

Value Chain or building up the ROE	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017
ROS (Income / Sales)	*0.4%*	*-0.3%*	*0.6%*	*1.7%*	*1.7%*
Turnover (Sales / Total Assets)	*1.9*	*1.6*	*1.7*	*1.6*	*1.4*
ROA (Income / Total Assets)	*0.7%*	*-0.4%*	*0.9%*	*2.8%*	*2.3%*
Leverage (Total Assets / Equity)	*4.1*	*5.1*	*4.8*	*4.3*	*4.7*
ROE (Income / Equity)	***3%***	***-2%***	***4%***	***12%***	***11%***
RONA (EBIT / Net Assets)	*12%*	*3%*	*15%*	*22%*	*8%*

Valuation	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017
Market Cap. (Bill.$)	*183*	*144*	*318*	*358*	*566*
Change in Market Cap.	*61%*	*-21%*	*121%*	*12%*	*58%*
Market Cap. / EBITDA	*46*	*28*	*37*	*29*	*37*

Source: Bloomberg and authors' editing.

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Exhibit 2
Amazon.com Inc. Balance Sheet

Balance sheet (Bill.$)	*2013*	*2014*	*2015*	*2016*	*2017*	*Change 2013-17*
Cash, Cash Equivalents & STI	12	17	20	26	31	*19*
Accounts Receivable, Net	5	6	6	8	13	*8*
Inventories	7	8	10	11	16	*9*
Total Current Assets	**25**	**31**	**36**	**46**	**60**	***36***
Total Non-current Assets	**16**	**23**	**29**	**38**	**71**	***56***
TOTAL ASSETS	**40**	**55**	**65**	**83**	**131**	*91*
Payables & Accruals	20	23	27	34	47	*26*
ST Debt	2	4	3	5	6	*5*
Other ST Liabilities	1	2	3	5	5	*4*
Total Current Liabilities	**23**	**28**	**34**	**44**	**58**	
LT Debt	5	12	14	15	38	*33*
Other LT Liabilities	2	3	3	5	8	*6*
Total Non-current Liabilities	**7**	**16**	**17**	**20**	**46**	
TOTAL LIABILITIES	**30**	**44**	**51**	**64**	**104**	
TOTAL EQUITY	**10**	**11**	**13**	**19**	**28**	*18*
TOTAL LIABILITIES & EQUITY	**40**	**55**	**65**	**83**	**131**	*91*

SHORT balance sheet (Bill.$)	*2013*	*2014*	*2015*	*2016*	*2017*	*Change 2013-17*
NFO	-9	-11	-15	-19	-22	***-13***
NCA, non-current assets	16	23	29	38	71	***56***
NA, net assets	**6**	**13**	**14**	**19**	**49**	***42***
Other long term free financing	2	3	3	5	8	***6***
D, Debt (short & long term)	7	16	18	20	44	***37***
E, Equity	10	11	13	19	28	***18***
Financing	**19**	**30**	**34**	**45**	**80**	***61***
Cash	*12*	*17*	*20*	*26*	*31*	***19***
Net Debt (Debt - Cash)	*-6*	*-1*	*-2*	*-6*	*13*	

Balance sheet ratios	*2013*	*2014*	*2015*	*2016*	*2017*
Current ratio (Current assets / Current liabilities)	*1.1*	*1.1*	*1.1*	*1.0*	*1.0*
Leverage (Liabilities / Equity)	*3.1*	*4.1*	*3.8*	*3.3*	*3.7*
Working Capital	*1.6*	*3.2*	*1.8*	*2.0*	*2.3*
NFO / Sales	***-12%***	***-12%***	***-14%***	***-14%***	***-13%***

Source: Bloomberg and authors' editing.

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Exhibit 3
Product and Markets. Selected Figures

Table 1. Net Sales by Business					***Sales***	***Growth***
(Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Mix 2017***	***Acc. 2014-17***
Retail on line	69	77	91	108	*61%*	*58%*
Retail Physical stores	0	0	0	6	*3%*	*na*
Market place. Third-party seller services	12	16	23	32	*18%*	*171%*
Subscription services	3	4	6	10	*5%*	*118%*
AWS	5	8	12	17	*10%*	*276%*
Other	1	2	3	5	*3%*	*252%*
Total net sales	**89**	**107**	**136**	**178**	***100%***	***100%***

Table 2. Net Sales by geographical Markets					***Sales***	***Growth***
(Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Mix 2017***	***Acc. 2014-17***
United States	55	71	90	120	*68%*	*120%*
Germany	12	12	14	17	*10%*	*42%*
United Kingdom	8	9	10	11	*6%*	*36%*
Japan	8	8	11	12	*7%*	*50%*
Rest of the World	6	7	11	17	*10%*	*181%*
Total net sales	**89**	**107**	**136**	**178**	***100%***	***100%***

Table 3. Net Sales by Segments					***Sales***	***Growth***
(Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Mix 2017***	***Acc. 2014-17***
North America	51	64	80	106	*60%*	*109%*
International	34	35	44	54	*31%*	*62%*
AWS Amazon Web Services	5	8	12	17	*10%*	*276%*
Total net sales	**89**	**107**	**136**	**178**	***100%***	***100%***

(*) Sales of the international segment were negatively affected in 2015 by exchange rates changes

Table 4. Operating Income (EBIT) by Segments					***EBIT***	***Change***
(Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Mix 2017***	***2014-17***
North America	0.4	1.4	2.4	2.8	*69%*	*2.5*
International	-0.6	-0.7	-1.3	-3.1	*-75%*	*-2.4*
AWS	0.5	1.5	3.1	4.3	*105%*	*3.9*
Total EBIT (Op. Income)	**0.2**	**2.2**	**4.2**	**4.1**	***100%***	***3.9***

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Exhibit 3 (Continued)

Table 5. Total Assets by Segment					***Asset Mix***	***Change***
(Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Mix 2017***	***2014-17***
North America	13	17	22	36	*27%*	*23*
International	7	8	10	18	*14%*	*11*
AWS	7	10	13	19	*14%*	*12*
Corporate	28	30	38	59	*45%*	*31*
Consolidated	**55**	**65**	**83**	**131**	***100%***	***77***

Table 6. ROA = EBIT / Total Assets					***Change***
By Segments	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***2014-17***
North America	3%	8%	11%	8%	*5%*
International	-9%	-9%	-12%	-17%	*-8%*
AWS	7%	15%	24%	23%	*17%*
Consolidated	**0%**	**3%**	**5%**	**3%**	***3%***

Table 7. USA Retail Industry					***Growth***	***% of total***
Revenue (Bill.$)	***2014***	***2015***	***2016***	***2017***	***Acc. 14-17***	***Retail***
Retailing U.S.	**2,820**	**2,941**	**3,031**	**3,139**	**11%**	**100%**
Store-based Retailing	2,419	2,489	2,535	2,572	6%	82%
Internet Retailing	245	285	330	383	56%	12%
Of which, Amazon on line	69	77	91	108	58%	3%
Other: Home shop., Direct sell., Vending	156	167	166	184	18%	6%
Retail World	**14,134**	**13,395**	**13,559**	**14,227**	**1%**	**100%**
Internet Retailing World	875	1,010	1,237	1,475	68%	10%

Source: Amazon 10-K Form 2017, with our own calculation and presentation.

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Exhibit 4
Amazon's Competitors (Some)

Table 1. Leading U.S. Retailers. 2017. Data in Bill.$.

Company		Sales	CAGR 5Y	EBIT	Net Income	Assets	ROA	Market Cap.
Amazon	U.S.	178	26%	4	3	131	2%	566
Walmart	U.S.	486	2%	20	14	199	7%	203
CVS Health Corp	U.S.	185	11%	8	7	95	7%	74
Kroger Co	U.S.	115	9%	3	2	37	5%	31
Walgreens Boots Alliance Inc	U.S.	118	13%	5	4	66	6%	83

Table 2. Internet Retailers. 2017. Data in Bill.$.

Company		Sales	CAGR 5Y	EBIT	Net Income	Assets	ROA	Market Cap.
Amazon	U.S.	108	115%	4	3	131	2%	566
Alibaba	China	24	49%	7	6	74	9%	451
eBay	U.S.	8	5%	2	-1	26	-4%	39
Walmart	U.S.	58	19%	5	4	66	6%	203
Rakuten	Japan	8	16%	2	1	55	2%	15

Notes:

Sales refer solely to internet sales (e.g., Wallmart's total sales are 486bn and internet sales 58bn).

Table 3. Technology Giants (GAFAs). 2017. Data in Bill.$.

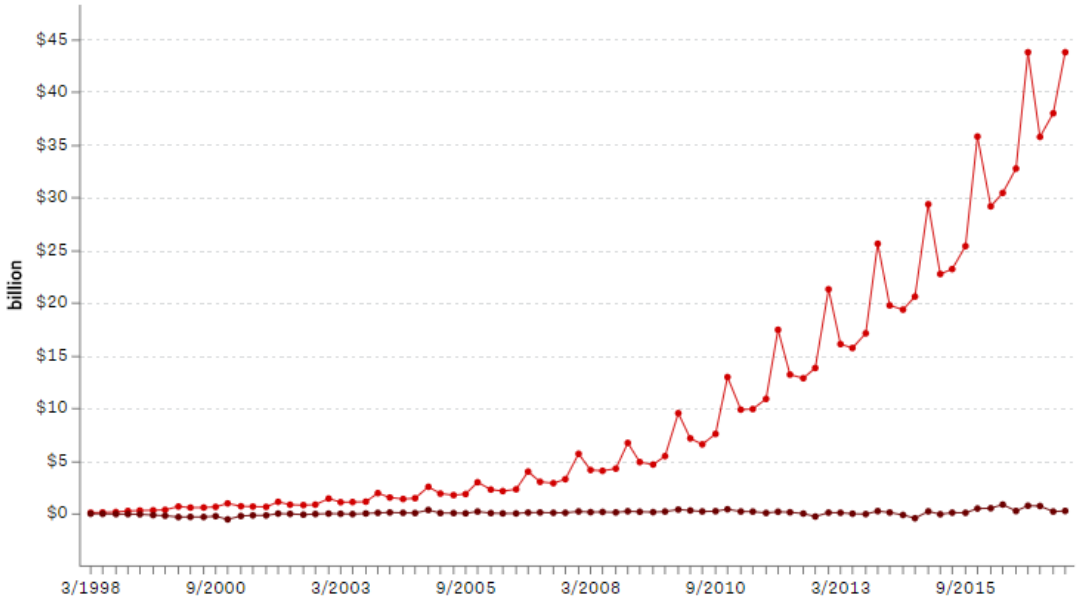
Company		Sales	CAGR 5Y	EBIT	Net Income	Assets	ROA	Market Cap.
Amazon	U.S.	178	26%	4	3	131	2%	566
Google	U.S.	111	20%	27	13	197	6%	732
Facebook	U.S.	41	48%	21	16	85	19%	513
Apple	U.S.	229	9%	64	48	375	13%	790

Source: Eikon.

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Exhibit 5
Other Information About Amazon

Table 1
Amazon's Quarterly Revenue Versus Net Income

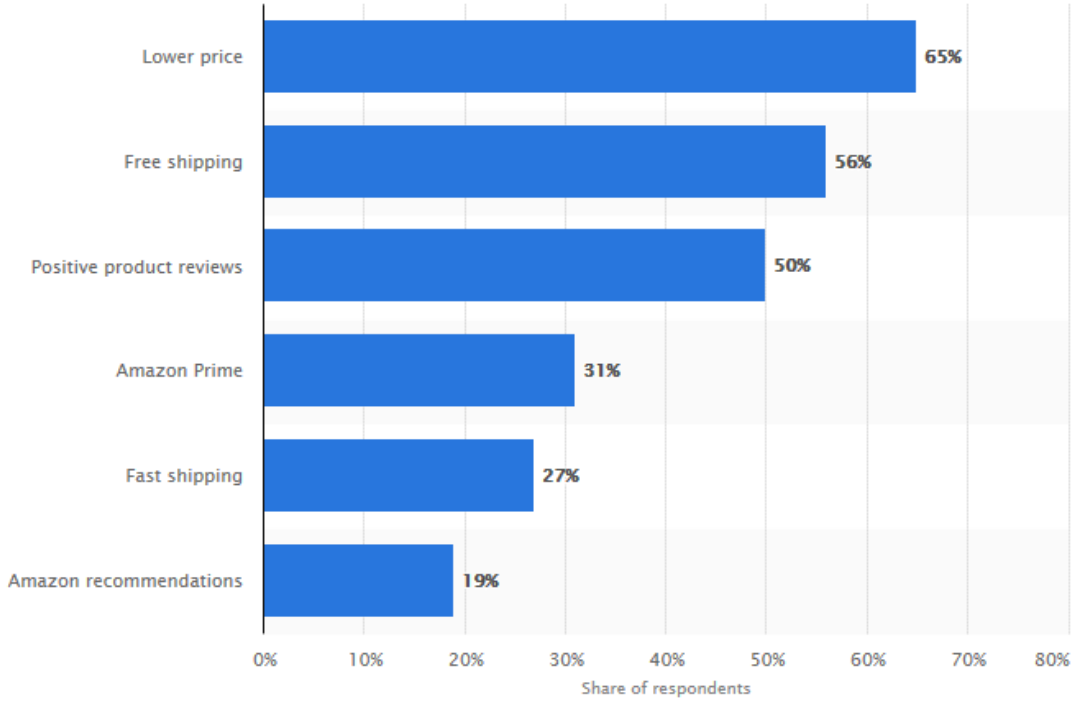


Source: Statista.

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Exhibit 5 (Continued)

Table 2
Main Reasons for U.S. Buyers to Shop Via Amazon (October 2017)

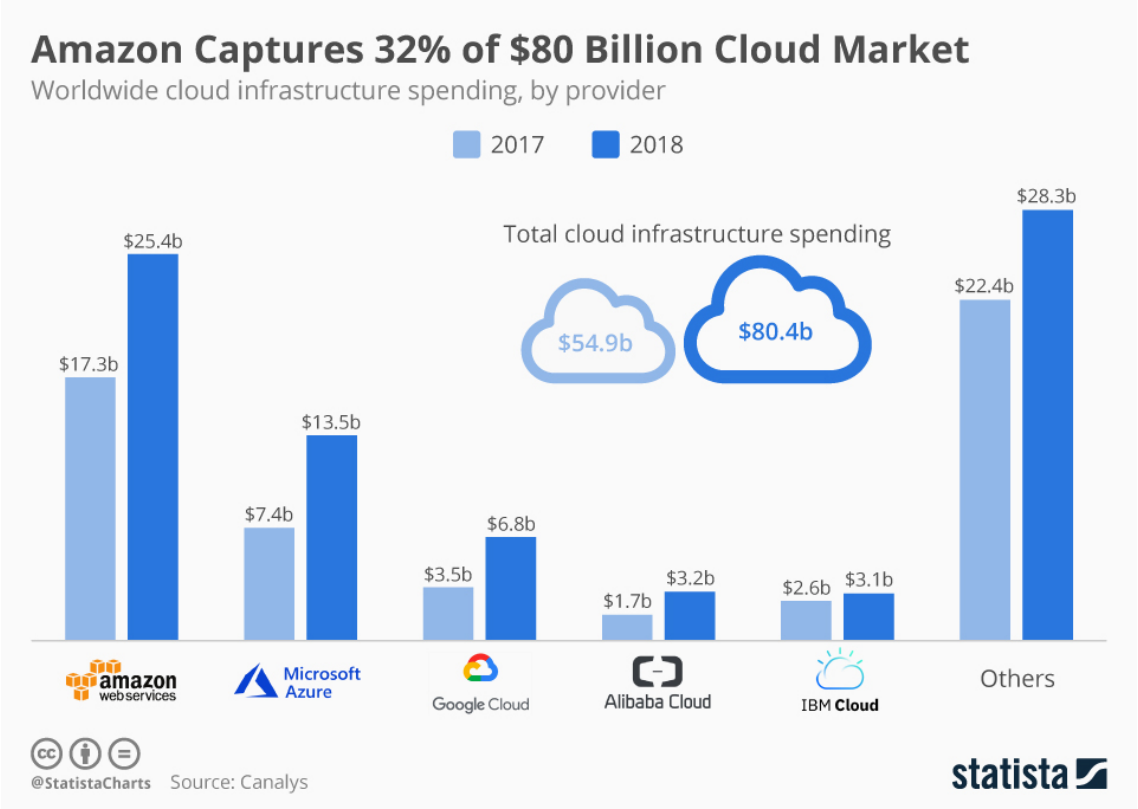


Source: Statista.

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Exhibit 5 (Continued)

Table 3
Cloud Market



Source: Statista.